



Sachin Tendulkar has 100 international tons, an artificial construct blending Tests and ODIs, but whatever the semantics, his 114 at Perth's WACA in 1992 is still considered his best outing. V.V.S. Laxman's 281 at Eden Gardens in 2001, against flint-eyed Steve Waugh and his men, is perhaps the greatest knock ever played by an Indian in Tests.

That Houdini Act by Sourav Ganguly's men in delirious Kolkata, wherein a first-innings deficit and a follow-on were tided past to register a miraculous victory, turbo-charged the India-Australia rivalry.

It added the weight of expectations and extreme spice, two ingredients that even the present generation of cricketers strictly adhere to while adding fresh chapters of intrigue and excitement.

While India embarks on the latest five-Test series for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy Down

Under, there are hopes about a stirring new tale being gifted to eager fans, be it the ones in Australia or those in India, bleary-eyed after waking up early to catch the action on television.

However, in the past, the immediate presumption was that India would tour Australia and lose to the blitz of pace, while at home, it would quell the opposition with spin and guile. Part of this Nostradamus syndrome was true, but there have always been surprises, and that is the

**Fightback for the ages:** In January 2021, Rishabh Pant's brilliant 89 piloted India's stunning run-chase, handing Australia its first defeat at the Gabba since 1988. India won the Border-Gavaskar series 2-1. GETTY IMAGES

charm of these two squads, with a long evolution resting on past champions.

In the 1980-81 tour of Australia, India staged the 'Miracle of Melbourne'. Trailing 0-1 after two



**Ravi Shastri, the Mumbaikar with an innate Aussie spirit, remains the link between Indian cricket of the past and the present. It is a continuity he still fosters as a commentator.**